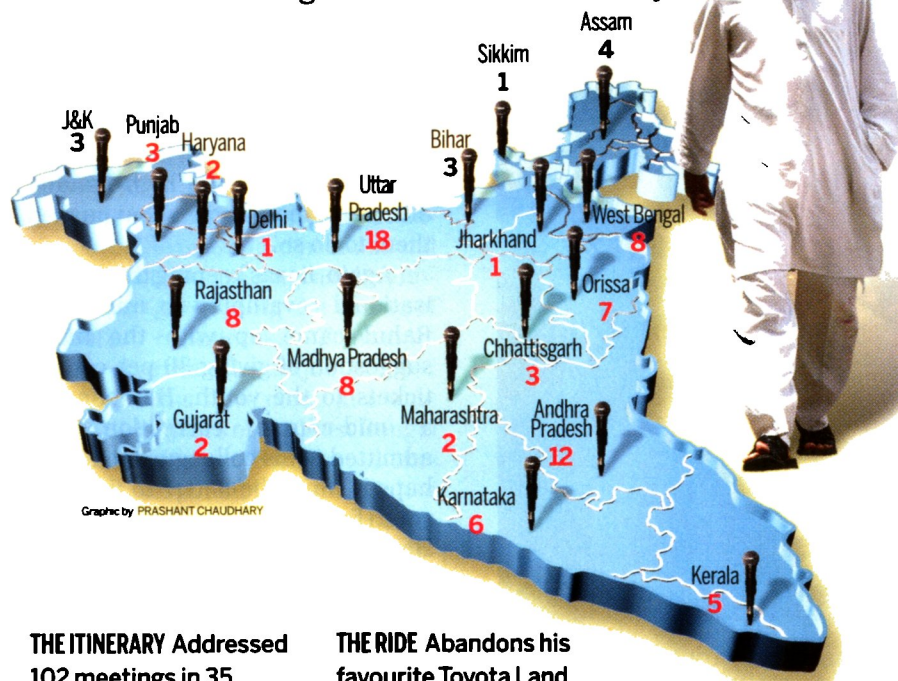


The Campaign FACT FILE

The Gandhi blitzkrieg has hit 19 states in 35 days



THE ITINERARY Addressed 102 meetings in 35 days and visited 97 constituencies.

THE LOOK White kurta and black sandals.

THE ACCESSORIES A rakhi tied by sister Priyanka, a religious thread and a white friendship band with squiggles presented by a niece from his mother's side.

THE RIDE Abandons his favourite Toyota Land Cruiser for locally arranged Innovas when he visits far-flung areas.

CAMPAIGN READ *Through our Enemies' Eyes* by Anonymous. The book is about Osama bin Laden and radical Islam. Touted as a "must read" for those who want to understand terrorism.

THE FOOD *Nimbu paani* has replaced Diet Coke of the Uttar Pradesh state elections. Is a non-fussy eater, often snacking on a rolled roti on the campaign trail. Has a sweet tooth like his dad. Specially enjoyed the West Bengal tour as he made it a point to try each and every sweet offered to him.

take on the BJP stalwart Ananth Kumar from Bangalore South.

Still, Rahul is never short of words that denote a cultural shift. Even though he is the most privileged beneficiary of hereditary rights in this party, he wants to be the champion of inner-party democracy. "Just because I am the outcome of a system does not mean that I cannot change it," he says, adding, "It also gives me a position to do certain things. I consider it my honour and duty to change the system of which I am a product."

Yet there is very little evidence of this blueprint at the ground level. Most of the young fresh faces that got tickets were from local dynasties. Take the example of Punjab where eight new faces were fielded and three of them were from privileged families: Captain Amarinder Singh's son Raninder, Beant Singh's grandson Ravneet Singh Bittu and Sukhwinder Singh Danny, son of a former Punjab minister Sardool Singh. He is boyishly proud of the fact that the election process has reached the Youth Congress with Punjab being the first off the block. Yet when he touts Punjab as a showcase, it is ironical that the man to emerge victorious from this little experiment with democracy is Bittu. "There is an expectation that democracy will come just by pressing a switch. You have to start

Look Ma, **BOTH HANDS!** Decoding Rahul's body language as he walks his talk



From the heat and dust of Election 2009 has emerged Rahul Gandhi, the orator. A suave, self-assured public speaker who doesn't read from prepared speeches. But what explains the Gandhi scion's peculiar body language in his speaking engagements—his two hands gripping the lectern. This is what speakers know as the "double-handed death grip" and what myriad books on public-speaking warn against. We got conflicting diagnoses from the two psychiatrists we consulted. Dr Harish Shetty says that the peculiar grip reflects fear and insecurity. "When you are holding the lectern the way Rahul is, you are trying to cling on to something or seeking an anchor," he says. The deeper meaning could be more ominous. "It probably has to do with the realisation that his father was assassinated after delivering a speech," he says. But there's hope. Dr Jitendra Nagpal feels that Rahul's body language signifies "progressive levels of confidence and self-esteem. People who do this want to show that they are ready to meet challenges."

by Sandeep Unnithan